

A Historical and Cartographic Analysis of Great Tartary

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Introduction

For centuries, the term “Great Tartary” or Tartaria evoked a vast, enigmatic expanse on European maps, stretching from the Caspian Sea to the Pacific Ocean [1, 9]. It was a name that conjured images of the Mongol hordes, the distant Silk Road, and a territory largely beyond the comprehension of the Western world. This report provides a balanced and scholarly analysis of Great Tartary, examining its representation in historical records and cartography. The objective is to deconstruct the term, moving from its use as a geographical label to understanding the actual governance and trade of the peoples who inhabited this region. Furthermore, the report will analyze the Great Wall of China’s role as a defensive frontier against these northern groups and conclude with a critical comparison of mainstream historical scholarship with modern alternative theories that have re-contextualized “Tartary” as a lost global empire [10].

This analysis will demonstrate that “Tartary” was a European exonym—a placeholder for a diverse and complex region [1, 9]. Its gradual disappearance from maps was not the result of a conspiratorial erasure but a natural evolution of geographical knowledge, driven by imperial expansion, scientific exploration, and the replacement of vague, historical labels with precise political and administrative designations [1, 11].

The Cartographic Record of Tartary

The story of Tartary is, first and foremost, a story of cartography. Its appearance, evolution, and eventual disappearance from maps chart the course of Europe’s growing awareness of the Asian continent.

Origins and Early Depictions (Pre-1750)

From the 13th century onwards, following the Mongol invasions of Europe, the term “Tartar” became a common, if imprecise, descriptor for the Mongol and Turkic peoples of the Eurasian Steppe [9]. European writers often added an extra ‘r’ to the name, conflating it with Tartarus, the abyss of torment in Greek mythology, which reflected the fear and awe inspired by the Mongol conquests [1, 9]. “Tartary” thus became the European name for the lands these peoples inhabited.

For cartographers of the early modern period, “Tartary” was a “cognitive placeholder for complexity, diversity, and scale” [1]. It was a convenient label for a region that was poorly understood, with information often drawn from a mixture of ancient accounts, traveler’s tales like Marco Polo’s, and pure speculation [1, 2].

A prime example is Abraham Ortelius’s influential atlas, *Theatrum Orbis Terrarum* (1570). It featured a map titled *Tartaria siue magni chami imperivm* (“Tartaria or the kingdom of the great Cham”) [1, 2].

* **Depiction:** Ortelius presented Tartary as a single, immense kingdom stretching from the Volga River to the Pacific. It was an anachronistic attempt to map the historical Mongol Empire, complete with an illustration of the “great Cham” (Khan), even though the empire had fragmented centuries earlier [1, 2].

* **Geography:** The map was geographically speculative, missing the Korean and Kamchatka peninsu-

las and placing North America just across a narrow, non-existent “Strait of Anian” [1, 2]. It depicted the Great Wall of China as a clear southern boundary, reinforcing the region’s identity as the land “beyond the wall” [2].

* **Content:** The map was filled with annotations from Marco Polo’s accounts, noting the supposed location of the ancient Mongol capital, **Karakum**, and mythical features like devils and dragons in the Lop Desert, as seen in later maps by cartographers like Willem & Joan Blaeu [2, 6].

Throughout the 17th century, mapmakers like Gerard Mercator and Nicolaes Visscher continued to show “Tartaria” as a vast, undifferentiated territory, reinforcing the idea of a single geographical zone inhabited by diverse nomadic peoples rather than a unified political state [1, 5].

The Transformation and Subdivision (Post-1750)

The mid-18th century marked a significant shift. As the Russian Empire expanded eastward and European explorers and missionaries gathered more accurate data, the monolithic “Tartary” of old maps began to fracture into more specific, politically relevant regions [1, 9]. This transition reflected a move from speculative geography to one based on empirical survey and administrative reality.

Maps from this period began to feature multiple “Tartaries,” each with a modifier indicating its political affiliation or geographical location [1, 9]:

* **Muscovite or Russian Tartary:** This referred to the territories in North Asia being absorbed by the Russian Empire. This term was a direct predecessor to **Siberia** [1, 9].

* **Chinese Tartary:** This label was applied to regions under the influence or control of China’s Qing Dynasty, including Manchuria and Mongolia [1, 9].

* **Independent Tartary:** This designated the khanates of western Central Asia (modern-day Uzbekistan, Kazakhstan, etc.), which remained, for a time, outside direct Russian or Chinese control [1, 9].

* **Little Tartary:** This term was used for the Crimean Khanate and adjacent lands north of the Black Sea [1, 9].

The work of French cartographer Guillaume de L’Isle, such as his *Carte de Tartarie* (c. 1706), was pioneering in this regard [1, 8]. De L’Isle meticulously used the latest reports from travelers to delineate these different Tartaries, offering a more nuanced, though still incomplete, picture of the region’s political landscape [1, 8].

The Disappearance of a Toponym

By the late 19th century, the term “Tartary” had become obsolete and vanished from maps [1, 9]. This was not an act of suppression but the logical outcome of several historical processes:

1. **Russian Imperial Consolidation:** As the Russian Empire solidified its administrative control over North and Central Asia, the name “Muscovite Tartary” was officially and universally replaced by **Siberia**, a term derived from the Siberian Khanate conquered in the 16th century [1, 9]. The region was now mapped with specific governorates and administrative boundaries.

2. **The “Great Game”:** The 19th-century strategic rivalry between the British and Russian Empires in Central Asia spurred intensive surveying and mapping for military and political purposes [33, 34]. The ambiguous “Independent Tartary” was replaced with precise names like Turkestan, Bukhara, and Khiva [33].

3. **Scientific Geography:** The Enlightenment brought a new standard of scientific rigor to cartography. Explorers and geographers like Alexander von Humboldt introduced new, scientifically grounded terms like “Central Asia,” which provided a more accurate framework for understanding the continent [9].

An 1885 map by G.W. & C.B. Colton & Co., for instance, shows no “Tartary” [1]. The area is clearly labeled with its modern political and geographical names: “Turkestan,” “Mongolia,” “Manchuria,” and

the provinces of the Russian and Chinese empires. The evolution was complete: a placeholder for the unknown had been replaced by the reality of the known.

Historical Realities of the Region

While European maps depicted a vague “Tartary,” the region itself was home to complex societies with distinct systems of governance and vibrant economic networks. To understand the history of the area, one must look beyond the cartographic label to the people themselves.

Governance: The Khanate Model

The dominant political structure across the Eurasian Steppe was the **khanate**, a semi-centralized monarchy rooted in tribal loyalty and military power [14, 17]. These were not parts of a single “Tartarian Empire” but were distinct, often competing, political entities that rose and fell.

* **Tribal Hierarchy:** The foundation of steppe society was the clan, which formed larger tribes. These tribes would often unite into confederations for mutual defense or conquest, led by a charismatic leader who earned the title of **Khan** [17].

* **Legitimacy and Succession:** In the lands of the former Mongol Empire, legitimacy was often tied to the **Chinggisid principle**, which held that only direct male descendants of Genghis Khan could be the supreme ruler [13]. However, with no strict rule of succession, this often led to intense rivalries and civil wars. Important decisions and the election of a new khan were often made in a council of tribal leaders known as a **kurultai** [13].

* **Administration:** Governance was often dualistic. Nomadic populations typically lived under traditional customary laws, such as the Yassa of Genghis Khan. In conquered territories with settled populations, local administrative structures were often left in place. For example, in the Chagatai Khanate, sedentary Muslim cities were allowed to live under Islamic Sharia law, provided they remained loyal and paid tribute [16]. This administrative flexibility was a hallmark of steppe empires, but it also worked against the formation of a single, monolithic state [15, 16].

Trade: The Fur Road and Silk Road Connections

The economy of the region was far from isolated. While the Silk Road is the most famous trade network, the “northern fur road” running through the Siberian forests was equally vital [18, 19].

* **“Soft Gold”:** The Siberian fur trade was a major economic driver, supplying highly prized furs to China, Persia, and Europe [19, 21]. The most valuable of these was sable, often called “soft gold” for its immense worth [19]. A single prime sable pelt in the 16th century could be worth more than a peasant family’s annual income [19]. Other valuable furs included ermine, black fox, and beaver [19].

* **Trade Networks:** This fur trade was deeply connected to the broader Eurasian economy. Furs were transported south to be exchanged for Chinese silk, cotton, and tea, particularly through formalized trade routes like the one at Kyakhta, established in 1727 [20]. To the west, furs provided Russia with the capital to purchase manufactured goods, textiles, and firearms from Europe [21].

* **The Role of the Russian State:** The Russian expansion into Siberia was fueled by this “fur fever” [19]. The state established a system of tribute known as **yasak**, requiring indigenous Siberian peoples to pay an annual tax in furs [19]. This system not only generated enormous revenue for the tsarist treasury—at its peak, accounting for over 10% of the state’s income—but also drove the administrative consolidation of Siberia, further contributing to the replacement of “Tartary” on maps [19].

The Great Wall of China: A Defensive Frontier

The Great Wall of China stands as a monumental testament to the long and complex relationship between the settled, agricultural civilization of China and the nomadic peoples of the steppe—the very people Europeans labeled “Tartars.”

Historical Purpose and Construction

The Great Wall was not a single project but a series of fortifications built, rebuilt, and expanded by various Chinese dynasties over centuries [25]. Its primary purpose was always defensive: to protect China from raids and invasions by northern nomadic groups like the Xiongnu, the Mongols, and the Manchus [22, 25].

* **Dynastic Efforts:** While early walls were built as far back as the 7th century BCE, the most extensive and well-preserved sections seen today were built during the **Ming Dynasty (1368-1644)** [22, 25]. The Ming adopted a largely defensive posture against the Mongol tribes to their north, and their construction efforts were immense [22, 24].

* **Defensive Orientation:** The wall was a sophisticated military system, not just a simple barrier. Its orientation was unequivocally northward [23]. Key features included:

* **Watchtowers and Beacon Towers:** Placed at regular intervals, these were used for observation and rapid communication via smoke signals or fire [23].

* **Fortresses and Passes:** Heavily fortified garrisons were built at strategic choke points and trade routes, such as the famous Juyong and Daoma passes [22].

* **Crenellations and Loopholes:** The top of the wall was designed for defense, with crenels on the outer (northern) side for archers to shoot from, while the inner side had a low parapet to protect soldiers from falling [23].

The wall was a clear demarcation line, a physical manifestation of the boundary between two different worlds: the settled, agrarian society of China to the south and the vast, nomadic realm of “Tartary” to the north.

The “Tartarian” Wall Theory: A Critical Reversal

In a complete reversal of the historical record, some alternative theories claim that the Great Wall was not built by the Chinese. Instead, they propose it was built by the “Tartarians” to keep the Chinese out [26, 30]. This theory suggests that the crenellations and defensive features face south, a claim that is demonstrably false upon physical inspection of the wall [26]. Mainstream scholarship, supported by overwhelming archaeological and textual evidence, confirms the wall’s Chinese origin and its defensive orientation against northern invaders [22, 25]. The theory of a “Tartarian” wall is a foundational element of the broader conspiracy narrative, but it lacks any factual basis [10, 26].

Mainstream Scholarship vs. Alternative Theories

In recent years, the historical term “Tartary” has been revived and radically reinterpreted by a pseudo-historical conspiracy theory that posits the existence of a global, technologically advanced “Tartarian Empire” [10, 30]. This narrative stands in stark contrast to the findings of mainstream historical and cartographic scholarship.

The Academic Consensus

Mainstream scholarship views “Tartary” through the lens of historical context and evidence. The consensus is clear:

* **A European Exonym:** “Tartary” was a label created by Europeans to describe a region and its peoples from an outsider’s perspective. The diverse groups living within this area would not have

identified as “Tartarians” [1, 9].

* **A Reflection of Limited Knowledge:** The vague and shifting boundaries of Tartary on early maps are direct evidence of Europe’s limited geographical knowledge, not evidence of a unified empire’s borders [1, 11].

* **An Evolutionary Process:** The cartographic history of Tartary shows a clear and logical progression. As knowledge increased through exploration, trade, and conquest, the vague umbrella term was naturally replaced by more precise and accurate names [1, 9, 11]. The disappearance of “Tartary” represents an increase in knowledge, not its suppression [11].

The “Tartarian Empire” Conspiracy Theory

The alternative theory proposes that a great “Tartarian Empire” was a global superpower with advanced technology (including atmospheric free energy), responsible for magnificent architecture worldwide [10, 31]. This empire was supposedly destroyed in the 19th century by a cataclysmic “mud flood” and then deliberately erased from history by a global cabal [10, 30].

A critical analysis reveals that this theory is built on misinterpretations and a lack of evidence:

* **Misinterpretation of Maps:** The theory mistakes a cartographic convention for a political entity [11, 35]. It treats a label for an unknown region as proof of a powerful, unified state. The Russian Geographical Society, which holds many of these historical maps, has actively debunked this interpretation, explaining it as an “extremist fantasy” [10].

* **Misinterpretation of Architecture:** Proponents claim that ornate 19th-century Beaux-Arts and classical revival buildings are “Tartarian” relics [26]. This ignores the well-documented history of these architectural styles and the construction records of the buildings themselves. The “mud flood” evidence—lower floors of old buildings being below ground level—is explained by the common urban phenomenon of street levels rising over centuries of development and infrastructure renewal [26, 30].

* **Lack of Evidence:** There is no archaeological, textual, or primary-source evidence for a global, technologically advanced Tartarian Empire [32]. The theory exists almost entirely in online forums and social media, unsupported by the standards of historical or scientific inquiry [10, 28, 29]. It substitutes a complex, evidence-based history of cultural interaction, imperial expansion, and scientific discovery with a simplistic and unsubstantiated narrative of a grand conspiracy.

Conclusion

The history of Great Tartary is a fascinating case study in how the Western world has perceived and mapped Asia. For centuries, it was a term of art, a cartographic convenience that encompassed a vast and diverse region of nomadic peoples, powerful khanates, and rich trade networks. The historical record shows that the peoples of this region, the so-called “Tartars,” possessed sophisticated systems of governance and were integral to the economic and political life of Eurasia.

The disappearance of “Tartary” from world maps was not a sinister act of historical erasure. It was the natural and inevitable result of the advancement of knowledge [1, 11]. As exploration filled in the blank spaces, as empires expanded and imposed new administrative realities, and as science provided new frameworks for understanding the world, the old, vague term was logically superseded. The maps, when read in their proper historical context, do not hide a lost empire; rather, they reveal a compelling story of our own journey from myth and speculation to empirical knowledge [1, 35].

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